



Prof. Kamakoti greeting former President, Dr APJ Abdul Kalam

our household with my reduced salary. This mutual understanding was crucial and turned our house into a home. These moments became pivotal in my life.”

From 2001 to 2009, before assuming the role of a professor, he worked on noteworthy projects involving hardware verification and development, collaborating with companies such as Intel and Xilinx on various projects. He also facilitated the placement of numerous students, with companies such as Open-Silicon and Intel hiring several of their graduates.

After joining IIT Madras, he embarked on a journey into VLSI. He was eager to work in an area that was underrepresented in the department. Prof. Kamakoti initiated a campaign to highlight VLSI as a field which has tremendous potential. He revived the CAD for the VLSI subject, which had previously been handled by someone else in his department but had come to a halt. The CS 6230 course, which he initiated in 2001, received significant interest, with 70 registrations.

However, he soon realised the need for commercial tools to support the course and create job opportunities. He remembers, “This is where Naveed Sherwani, Satya Gupta, and Chitra Hariharan, the co-founders of Open-Silicon, played a crucial role. We acquired essential tools for teaching, including licenses from Magma. With a humble beginning and under

\$10,000 from Open-Silicon and commercial EDA tools from Magma, with help from Anand Anandkumar, who was heading Magma India at that time. This marked the inception of my journey with VLSI at IIT Madras.”

IIT Madras alumni support was instrumental, with a funding of around \$60,000. Subsequently, another batch of alumni

from 1986 and 1982 contributed a substantial amount. This funding allowed him to expand the VLSI endeavours and further support doctoral students. “With this modest beginning, I embarked on my VLSI journey at IIT Madras, where we took on large-scale designs and even attempted to clone the x86 architecture given my knowledge in x86 instruction set architecture. This turned out to be a challenging task due to the complexity. In those days, the decoder, responsible for finding instruction boundaries in the fast-changing x86 instructions, was a significant accomplishment.

Around 2003, he got involved and led the Special Manpower Development Program initiated by the Ministry of Electronics, Government of India. Prof. Kamakoti, along with other members, formed the Reconfigurable Intelligence Systems Engineering (RISE) group, with a vision of engineering intelligent systems. He used to believe that systems would evolve to be more intelligent, and looking back, the name RISE stands apt today.

In 2009, when he assumed the role of a professor, it marked a turning point. He remembers, “I also became the vice-chairman of the Joint Entrance Examination (JEE) committee at IIT Madras, which was an interesting experience, although I earlier failed in that examination. A



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